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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

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Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S)

4. The Age-Group and its Political Significance

In a similar manner, the relationship to the other sex is regulated by age-group membership. Individuals belonging to a slightly older age-group will not allow their juniors to approach a girl whom they might woo. Like the Nuer, the Chaga stands in a joking relationship with girls of his own age, but for the latter this does not preclude marriage, whereas for the former it does. Exogamy among the Chaga is based on the principle of kinship, not age. In the past the members of an age-group married almost simultaneously. After the wife of the 'king of the camp' had become pregnant and had had her breasts covered ritually, the youths were at liberty to marry, 'which they do with alacrity, so that for months on end the whole country is the scene of a continuous series of marriages and the accompanying feasting'.²

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The age-group is not simply based on seniority. It expresses, in addition, a principle of human behaviour to which the term 'sex-antagonism' has been applied. The tendency of the two sexes to develop mutually exclusive types of conduct has a special function. For these types of conduct become in their perfection an ideal admired by a potential sexual partner. Chaga women sing songs that incite their lovers and husbands to battle. A coward had not only to carry his comrades' spears, but, on the return of the army, he was laden with a bunch of unripe bananas, cut so that their milky juice flowed over his face. He was taken to the market place and seated in the middle of the women. They mocked him, spat at him, and in pretence accepted him into their company by calling him 'woman'. Such a man was divorced from all his wives and his property confiscated. No wonder, then, that a brave man, having met an evil portent, but fearing to disgrace his wife or sweetheart, suppressed his dread and went to meet the enemy. On the other hand, a faithful wife would search for her wounded husband, dress his injuries, and carry him home. Thus, in the exclusiveness of the sexes is hidden the very spring that irresistibly urges them together.

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² Dundas, op. cit., p. 223, and G., R., p. 345.

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